A SPONSOR FOR THE PILOT

Washakie AI / Three Columns — after the County declined, 5 October 2026

Ask the Wyoming Business Council before building anything

The Business Council's own community grant guidelines list the eligible applicants as: local or regional leadership development programs; state leadership development organizations; economic and/or business development organizations; community development organizations; and **cities, towns, joint powers boards, or the Northern Arapaho and Eastern Shoshone tribes.**

Counties are not on that list. So Tertia's answer may be literally correct rather than a brush-off — the County may simply not be an eligible applicant for this family of grants, whatever its willingness. That also means creating a 501(c)(3) might not solve it either, unless the new organization reads as a "community development organization."

That list is from the Community Leadership Grants guidelines; the Community Economic Growth Grant may differ. Which is precisely why the first move is one email to the program, not $275 to the IRS.

> **Amber Power** — Community Leadership and Engagement Manager, Wyoming Business Council
> amber.power@wyo.gov · 307.287.9886
> Ask her two things, in four sentences: which entity types are eligible to apply for the Community Economic Growth Grant, and whether a county museum, a library foundation or a school district would qualify. An authoritative answer costs you nothing and decides everything below.

What fiscal sponsorship actually is

You do not create a nonprofit. An existing one applies, receives the money, and carries the reporting and audit obligations; you do the work under its name. The customary administrative fee is five to ten percent. It is ordinary practice and every grants officer knows the term.

A sponsor needs a reason to say yes, so offer one: the method itself, a site built for them as the first of the twelve, and their name on the published write-up. That turns a favor into a trade.

The candidates, best first

1. Washakie Museum & Cultural Center

2200 Big Horn Avenue, Worland · 307.347.4102 · EIN 83-0274740
Robyn Irons, Grants / Website Manager — rirons@washakiemuseum.org
Marian Bender, Executive Director — 20+ years of nonprofit management

Why first: they employ somebody whose actual job is grants, which no other candidate here does. The museum is the county's cultural institution, and small single-subject sites about local trades and local knowledge sit close to what a cultural center exists to do. Write to Robyn Irons rather than the director — a grants manager will understand "fiscal sponsorship" in the first sentence and can tell you in a day whether it is possible.

2. Washakie County Library Foundation, Inc.

Worland · EIN 74-2150737 · listed as a charitable organization, rated on Charity Navigator
A separate Friends of Washakie County Library group also exists.

Why: it exists for no purpose except to support the library, and the library is already a named partner in your proposal. Closest mission fit of anyone on this page. The open question is capacity — a small foundation run by volunteers may not want the administrative weight of a state grant, and that is a fair thing for them to say.

3. Washakie County School District No. 1

Tawn Argeris, Superintendent · 307-347-9286

Why: the strongest part of your pitch is high school pupils publishing their first real work, and a school board can approve that for its own reasons rather than as a favor to you. The catch is that a district is a governmental body, not a 501(c)(3), so whether it qualifies depends entirely on the Business Council's answer above.

4. Wyoming Community Foundation

Laramie · statewide, administers county affiliate and donor-advised funds

Why last: it is the organization most likely to understand fiscal sponsorship instantly and least likely to care about Worland specifically. Worth a call if the three local doors close, not before.

Two things to keep in view

There is no hurry. The deadline is 1 March 2027, and the grant runs on a March / September cycle. Nothing here needs deciding this month.

The conflict noted earlier still stands. StartUp Wyoming is run by the same Wyoming Business Council you would be asking for the grant. Worth remembering before the two approaches are made in the same season.